

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Catalan Opening

Open and closed Catalan structures, recovery methods, and long-diagonal pressure

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
01 - Foundation	2
02 - Open Catalan	8
03 - Closed Catalan	4
04 - Early Checks	2
05 - Immediate Central Challenge	2
06 - Transpositions	2

01. Catalan Core Setup - Move Order



01 - Foundation

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Catalan Core Setup structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks central solidity, ...dxc4, or ...c5 before the bishop becomes dominant.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan Core Setup.

01. Decision Framework

Catalan Core Setup - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

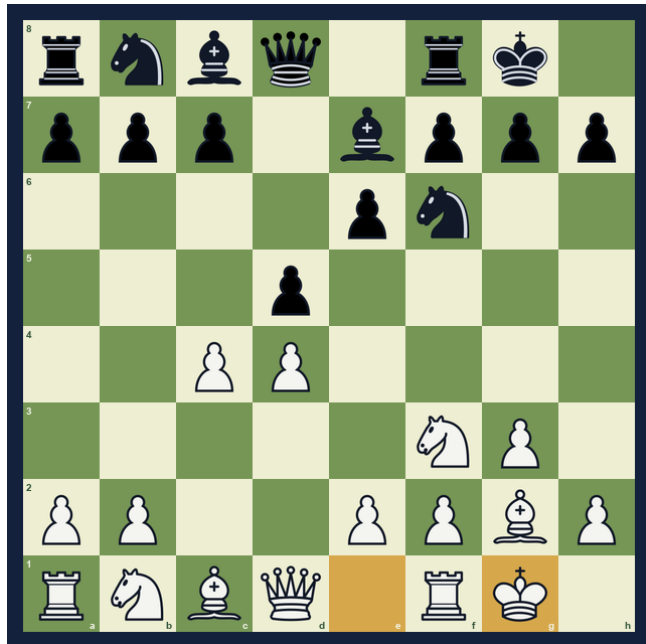
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan Core Setup.

02. Catalan Core Setup



01 - Foundation

READ THE POSITION

White combines Queen's Gambit central pressure with a long dark-square diagonal.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the bishop to pressure the queenside while preparing e4 or recovering c4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks central solidity, ...dxc4, or ...c5 before the bishop becomes dominant.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

The Catalan bishop is powerful when the center and queenside give it a real target.

02. Decision Framework

Catalan Core Setup

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

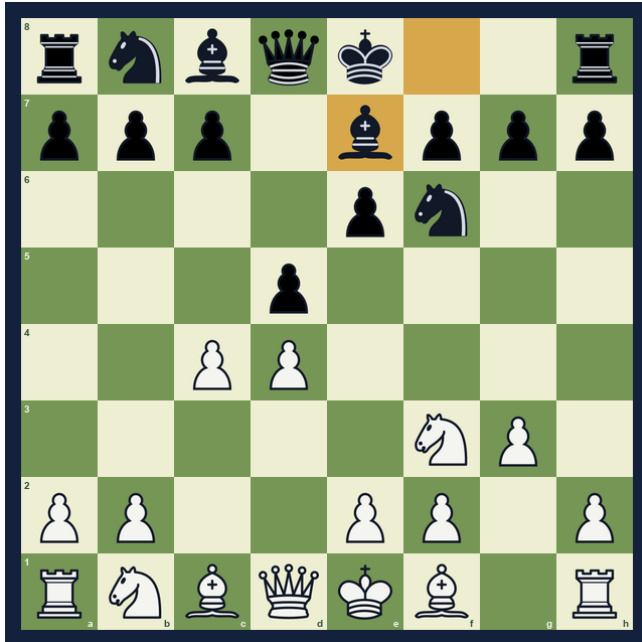
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The Catalan bishop is powerful when the center and queenside give it a real target.

03. Open Catalan with ...a6 - Move Order



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Open Catalan with ...a6 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black holds the pawn long enough to gain ...b5 or active piece play.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Open Catalan with ...a6.

03. Decision Framework

Open Catalan with ...a6 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Open Catalan with ...a6.

04. Open Catalan with ...a6



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 and builds queenside support while White gains central activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Recover the pawn through pressure, not queen adventures, and keep development flowing.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black holds the pawn long enough to gain ...b5 or active piece play.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O dxc4 7. Qc2 a6 8. a4 c5 9. dxc5

MEMORY RULE

In the Open Catalan, development and diagonal pressure recover the pawn.

04. Decision Framework

Open Catalan with ...a6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: In the Open Catalan, development and diagonal pressure recover the pawn.

05. Closed Catalan - Move Order



03 - Closed Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Closed Catalan structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses ...b6, ...Bb7, or ...c5 to free the position.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Closed Catalan.

05. Decision Framework

Closed Catalan - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Closed Catalan.

06. Closed Catalan



03 - Closed Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Black maintains a compact center while White builds long-term queenside pressure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Prepare e4 or b3 and improve pieces before releasing the tension.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses ...b6, ...Bb7, or ...c5 to free the position.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O Nbd7 7. Qc2 c6 8. Nbd2

MEMORY RULE

Closed Catalan play is a race between White's pressure and Black's freeing break.

06. Decision Framework

Closed Catalan

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

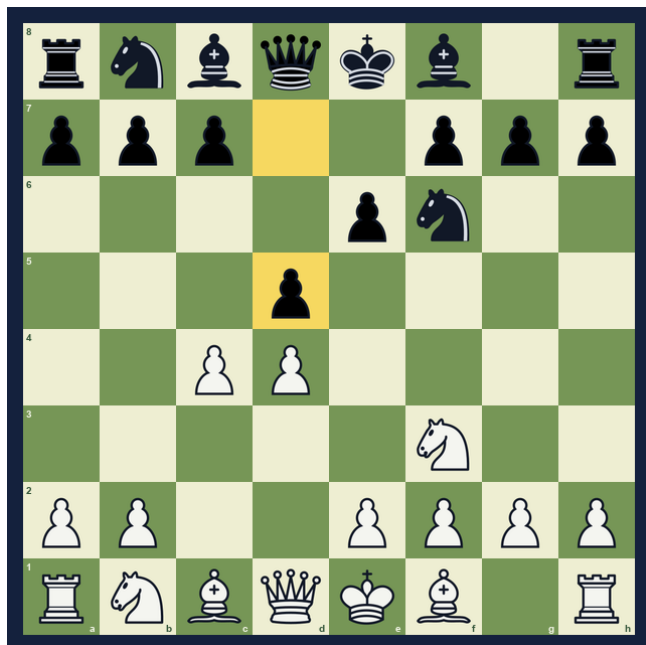
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Closed Catalan play is a race between White's pressure and Black's freeing break.

07. Open Catalan with ...Bb4+ - Move Order



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Open Catalan with ...Bb4+ structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black consolidates the extra pawn and seeks exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Open Catalan with ...Bb4+.

07. Decision Framework

Open Catalan with ...Bb4+ - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Open Catalan with ...Bb4+.

08. Open Catalan with ...Bb4+



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Black uses a check to slow White's development and support the c4-pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

Block or meet the check without weakening the diagonal, then attack c4 with coordinated pieces.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black consolidates the extra pawn and seeks exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 dxc4 5. Bg2 Bb4+ 6. Bd2 a5

MEMORY RULE

A checking move is useful only if the resulting piece placement supports the pawn structure.

08. Decision Framework

Open Catalan with ...Bb4+

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

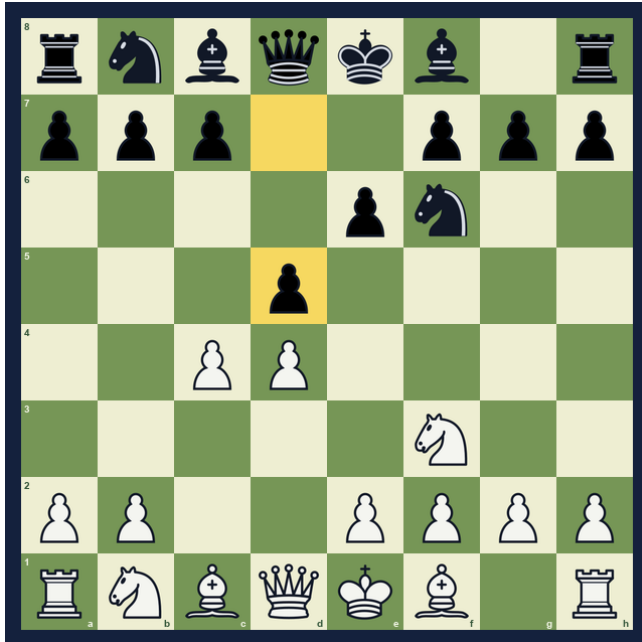
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A checking move is useful only if the resulting piece placement supports the pawn structure.

09. Catalan Check on b4 - Move Order



04 - Early Checks

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Catalan Check on b4 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black completes development and later decides between ...dxc4 and ...c5.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan Check on b4.

09. Decision Framework

Catalan Check on b4 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

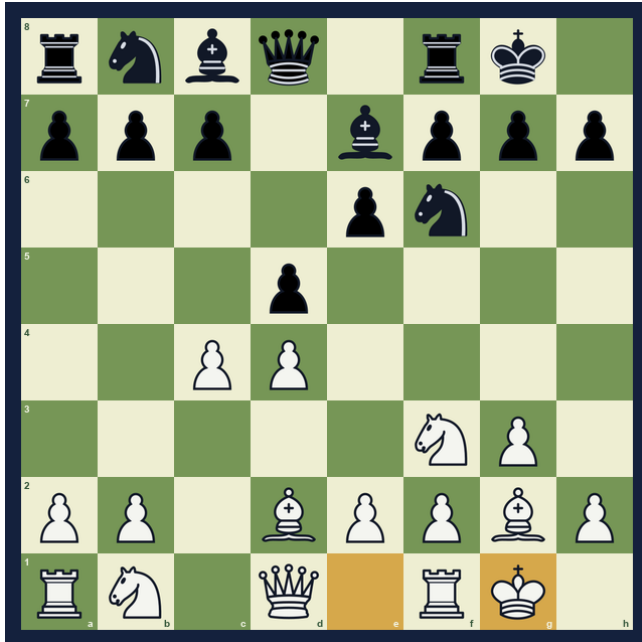
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan Check on b4.

10. Catalan Check on b4



04 - Early Checks

READ THE POSITION

Black checks before committing the center, testing White's bishop placement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop naturally and use the bishop on d2 only when it supports a recapture or exchange.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black completes development and later decides between ...dxc4 and ...c5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Bb4+ 5. Bd2 Be7 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Early checks change piece placement; they do not remove the Catalan's structural plans.

10. Decision Framework

Catalan Check on b4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

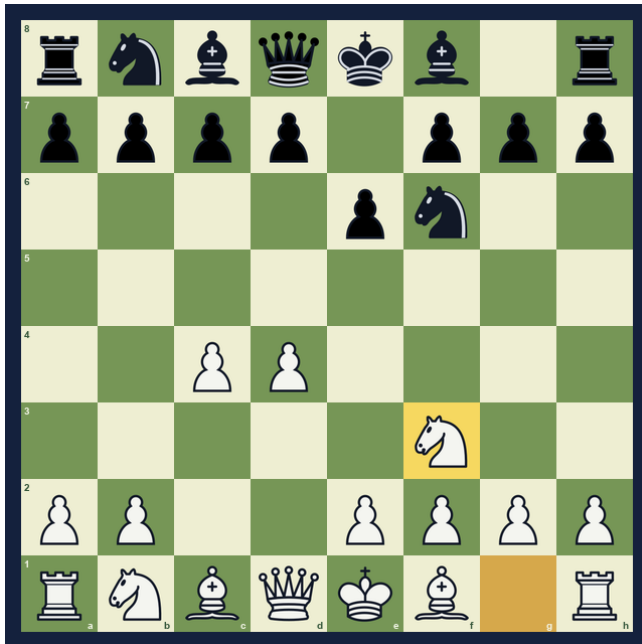
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Early checks change piece placement; they do not remove the Catalan's structural plans.

11. Catalan with ...c5 - Move Order



05 - Immediate Central Challenge

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Catalan with ...c5 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses active central play to prevent slow Catalan pressure.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan with ...c5.

11. Decision Framework

Catalan with ...c5 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

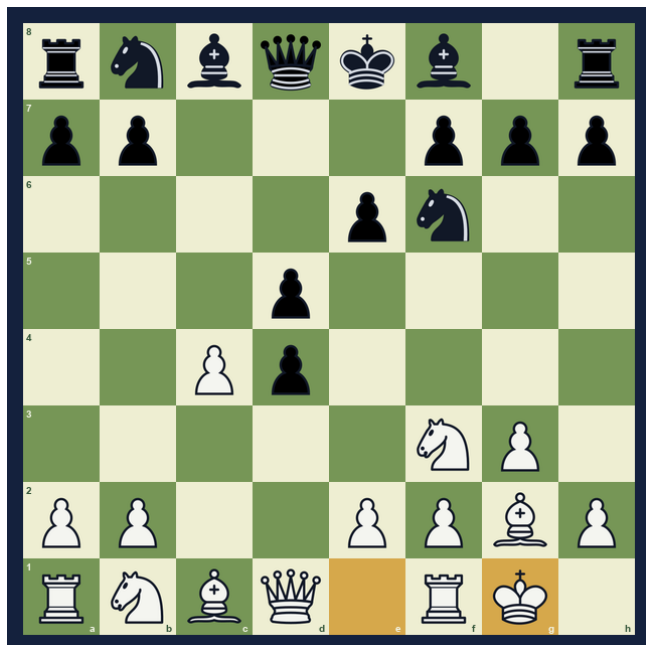
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan with ...c5.

12. Catalan with ...c5



05 - Immediate Central Challenge

READ THE POSITION

Black challenges d4 immediately and may create an isolated or hanging-pawn structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Recapture according to development and preserve the long diagonal.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses active central play to prevent slow Catalan pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 c5 5. Bg2 cxd4 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

When ...c5 arrives early, calculate the resulting pawn structure before choosing a recapture.

12. Decision Framework

Catalan with ...c5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When ...c5 arrives early, calculate the resulting pawn structure before choosing a recapture.

13. Queen Recovery on c4 - Move Order



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Queen Recovery on c4 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black develops by attacking the queen and contests the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Queen Recovery on c4.

13. Decision Framework

Queen Recovery on c4 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Queen Recovery on c4.

14. Queen Recovery on c4



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

White recovers the pawn immediately with a check but develops the queen early.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the recovered pawn balance to finish development without exposing the queen to tempi.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black develops by attacking the queen and contests the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 dxc4 5. Qa4+ Nbd7 6. Qxc4

MEMORY RULE

Immediate pawn recovery is useful only when the queen does not become Black's development plan.

14. Decision Framework

Queen Recovery on c4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

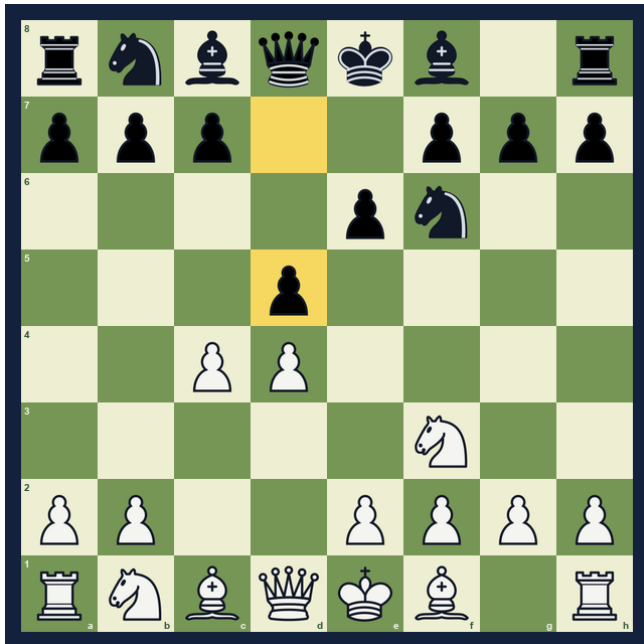
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Immediate pawn recovery is useful only when the queen does not become Black's development plan.

15. Catalan ...a6 and ...b5 - Move Order



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Catalan ...a6 and ...b5 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black gains space and protects c4 while accepting queenside targets.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan ...a6 and ...b5.

15. Decision Framework

Catalan ...a6 and ...b5 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan ...a6 and ...b5.

16. Catalan ...a6 and ...b5



02 - Open Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Black builds a queenside pawn chain to keep the extra pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack the chain's base, use a4, and open the long diagonal before the pawns consolidate.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black gains space and protects c4 while accepting queenside targets.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 dxc4 5. Bg2 a6 6. O-O b5

MEMORY RULE

Attack the base of the pawn chain, not the most advanced pawn.

16. Decision Framework

Catalan ...a6 and ...b5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

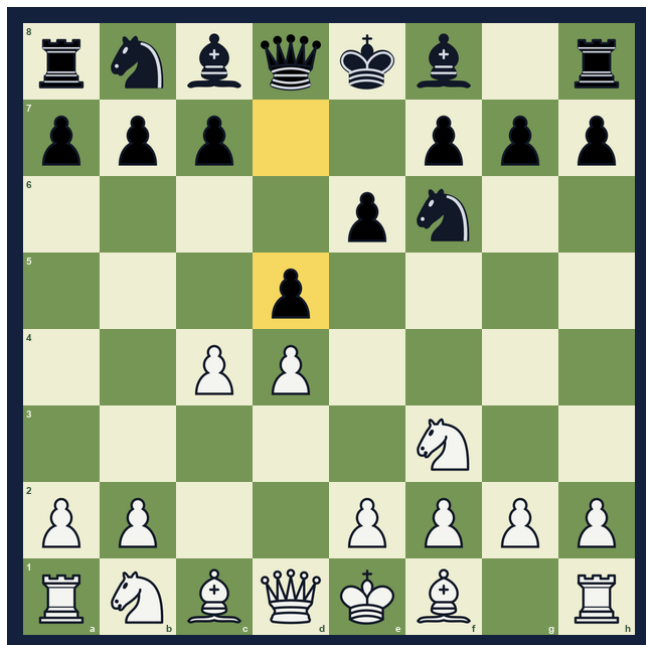
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Attack the base of the pawn chain, not the most advanced pawn.

17. Catalan with b3 - Move Order



03 - Closed Catalan

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Catalan with b3 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black may keep or return the pawn while seeking ...c5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan with b3.

17. Decision Framework

Catalan with b3 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

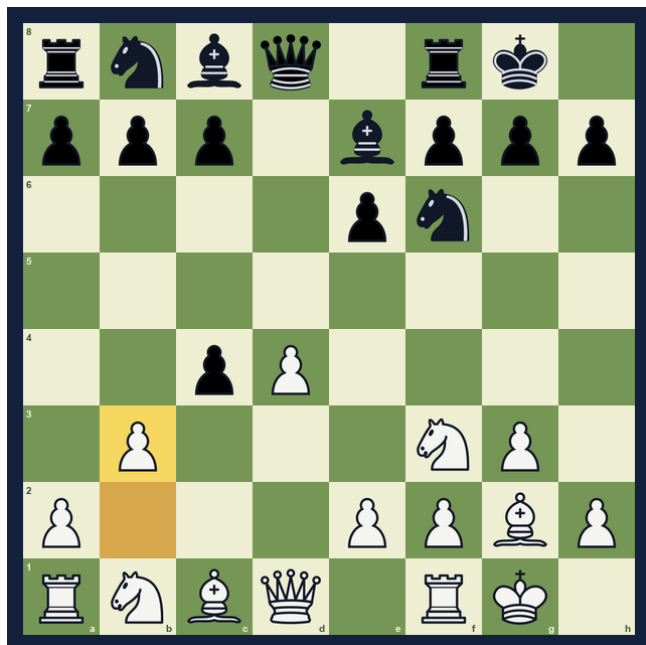
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan with b3.

18. Catalan with b3



03 - Closed Catalan

READ THE POSITION

White offers a queenside pawn exchange to open the bishop and recover c4 efficiently.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use bxc4 or Qc2 with rapid development and pressure on the diagonal.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black may keep or return the pawn while seeking ...c5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O dxc4 7. b3

MEMORY RULE

The b3 break is valuable because it opens the bishop, not merely because it recovers a pawn.

18. Decision Framework

Catalan with b3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The b3 break is valuable because it opens the bishop, not merely because it recovers a pawn.

19. Catalan Move Order - Move Order



06 - Transpositions

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Catalan Move Order structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black chooses a Queen's Gambit, Bogo-Indian, or closed setup according to the delayed center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 Nf6 2. g3 d5 3. Bg2

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan Move Order.

19. Decision Framework

Catalan Move Order - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Catalan Move Order.

20. Catalan Move Order



06 - Transpositions

READ THE POSITION

White reaches Catalan play while delaying the c- and d-pawn commitments.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use move-order flexibility to avoid unwanted systems without losing central control.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black chooses a Queen's Gambit, Bogo-Indian, or closed setup according to the delayed center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 Nf6 2. g3 d5 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d4 O-O 6. c4

MEMORY RULE

Move-order flexibility is useful when you still recognize the resulting structure.

20. Decision Framework

Catalan Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order flexibility is useful when you still recognize the resulting structure.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.